

Lesson: Fundamentals of the shot

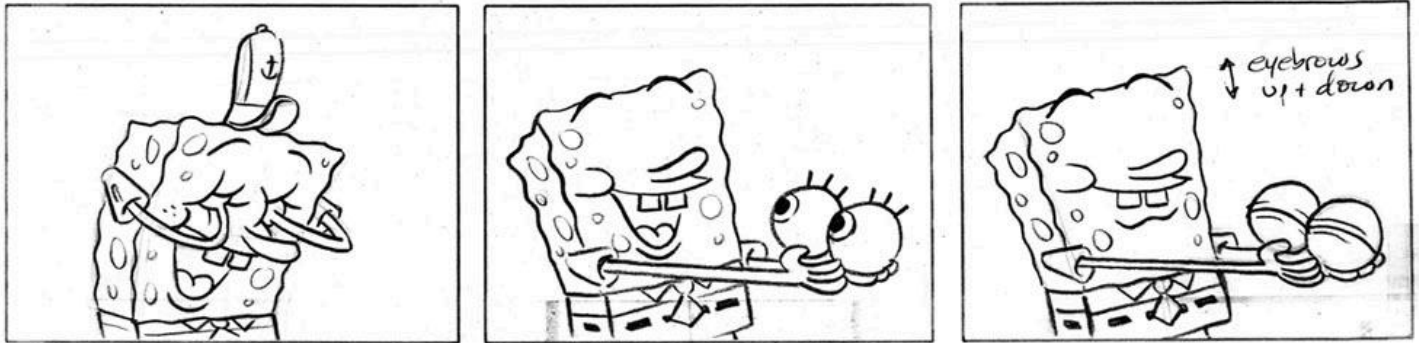
There are three things you must familiarize yourself with when working in film or television and those are **shots**, **sequences**, and **scenes**.

SHOTS

The most basic unit of production is the shot. A shot takes place from the time the record button on the camera is pressed until the time it is stopped.

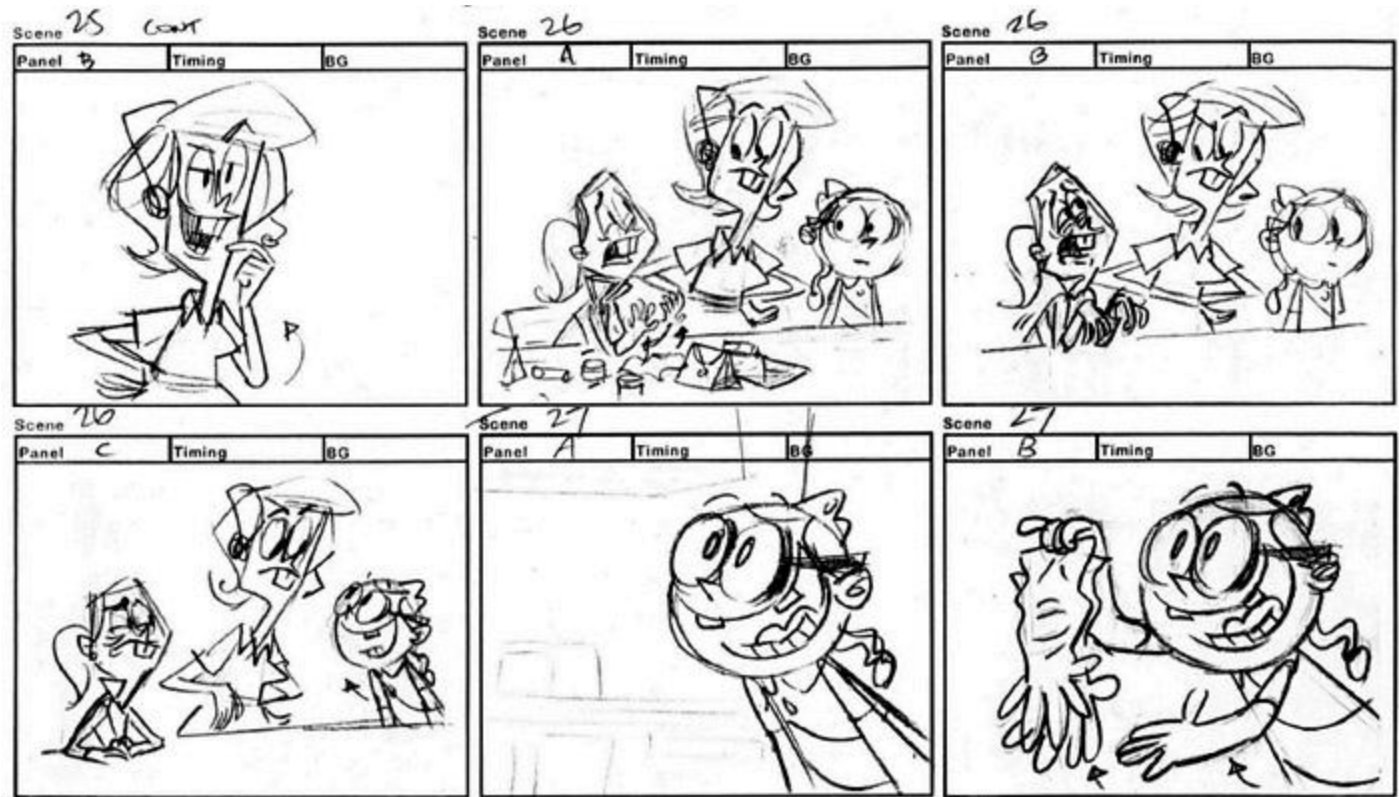
In some behind the scenes documentaries about films you will sometimes hear the director yell "And action!", and then a while later, "Cut!". Those two commands signify when the shot begins and ends. For a storyboard artist, the panel indicates each shot. However, some shots take place over a few panels like when the camera moves or there is enough significant action within the shot to indicate it in multiple panels.

In the example below, we can see Spongebob Squarepants reaching into his face, pulling out his eyes, and then his eyes blinking while he raises and lowers his eyebrows. These actions could not be illustrated in a single panel yet they constitute a single shot.



SCENES

Scenes contain multiple shots that are put together to show the actions taking place in one location or setting.



SEQUENCES

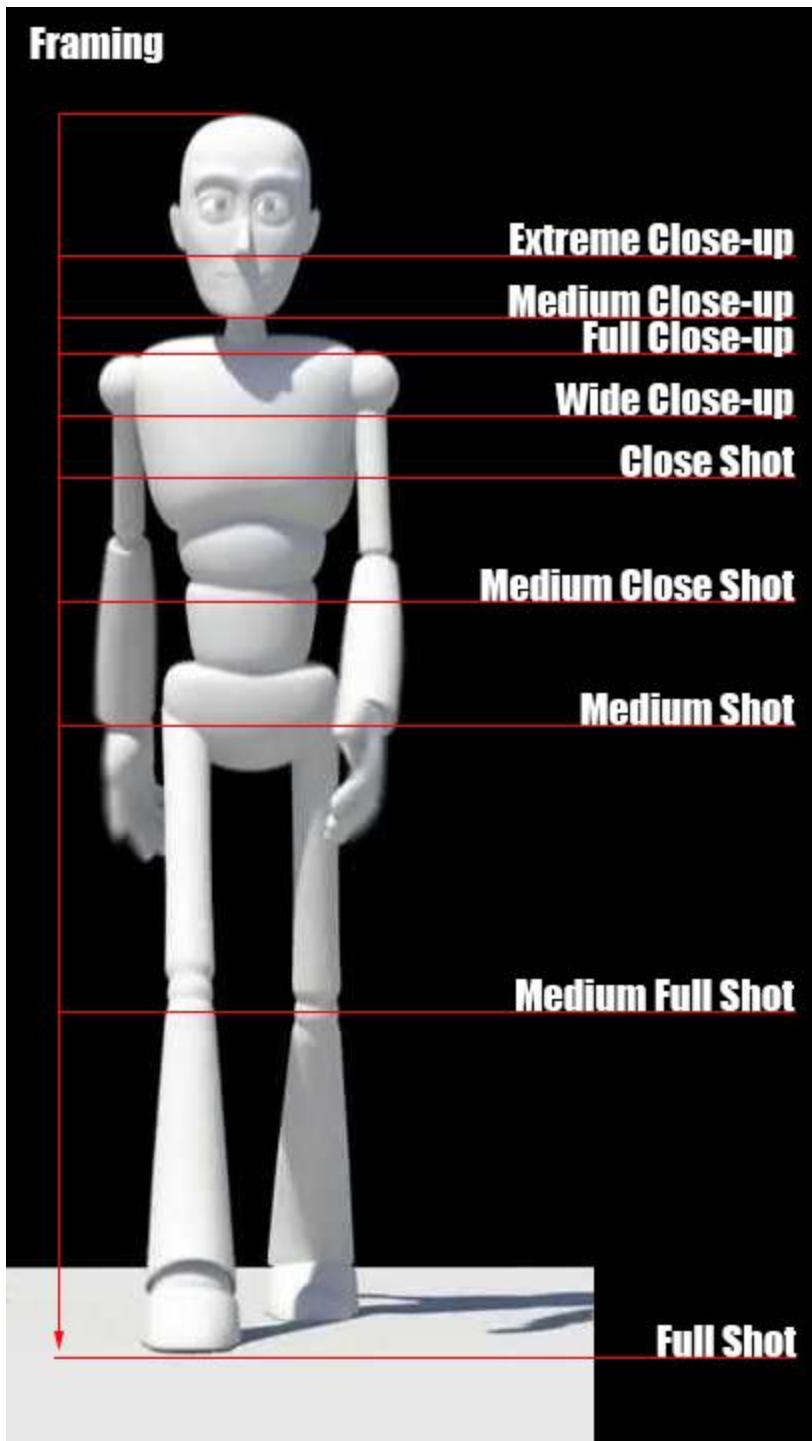
Sequences are a series of scenes strung together that create a flow of the story from one scene to the next. The director is responsible for determining how the sequences should look and feel, down to the actions within a shot.

As objectives are defined for a project there are three things to consider, **framing, angles, and movement**.

Framing

Framing is based on how close or far the subject is from the camera and is determined by the type of media that the project will play out in. Dramas, for instance, may move slower and include more close-ups than an epic adventure film that includes wider shots of sweeping views.

Framing of people is typically adjusted from the top of the head, downward.



You can begin planning your shot selections by following a basic formula: Start wide, go tight.

Wide shots are used to establish locations, show vast landscapes, or orient the viewer as to where the scene is taking place. A wide shot of Manhattan's skyline, for instance, will instantly indicate that the scene will be taking place in Manhattan. Tight shots, such as full shots, medium shots, and close-ups, create an interpersonal relationship between the viewer and the character. It brings us, the viewer, into the story taking place.

Here's how a typical sequence would be put together for the opening of a film.

Wide Shot - Manhattan skyline

Bird's Eye View - Flying over Manhattan

Long Shot - A shot looking down 5th Avenue

Full Shot - Character A walking towards the camera

Medium Shot - Character B stands waiting

Two Shot - Character A walks into frame meeting Character B

Close Shot - Character A speaks to Character B

Reverse Angle - Character B responds

Two Shot - Character A & B exchange a glance then part ways

Crane Up - Characters A & B disappear in opposite directions among the people on the crowded street.

Long Shot - Looking down 5th Avenue

We started at our widest shot, showing the Manhattan skyline, establishing where our scene is taking place and then getting all the way into a close-up of the characters exchanging dialogue, until we back out again to re-establish our location. Not every scene has to follow this formula, but it is a good starting point for choosing shots.

Some of the more typical shots are:

- Extreme Long Shot
- Full Shot
- Close-up
- Single Shot
- Insert Shot
- Long Shot / Wide Shot
- Medium Shot
- Extreme Close-up
- Two Shot

See pages 36 - 40 for more detailed explanations of some shots.

Angles

Camera angles grab the viewers attention by creating more dynamic scenes. They can influence how a viewer should perceive a situation or character.

Some of the more typical camera angles are:

- Low Angle
- Eye Level
- Tilt Up or Down
- Three-quarter
- Profile
- High Angle
- Bird's Eye View
- Canted Angle or Dutch Tilt
- Frontal
- Over-the-Shoulder

See pages 40 - 46 in the textbook for detailed explanations.

Movement

Cameras can remain static or move among characters to add more energy to the shot. A car chase, for example, showing a car coming up the street being chased by another car while the camera remains static, only showing the two cars passing out of frame doesn't offer much excitement to the scene. It merely established that one car is being chased by another. Now, take that camera and pan it as the cars pass and you've already added more excitement to that shot showing the cars coming closer, passing the camera, and then leaving in the opposite direction. Now throw in some shots showing the viewpoints of the drivers, looking into the rearview mirror of the lead car, and from the hood of the lead car looking past the driver showing the chase car following close behind and you've got one dynamic scene.

Example

[Gorillaz - Stylo.mp4 \(https://lynn.instructure.com/courses/27892/files/6478053/download?wrap=1\)](https://lynn.instructure.com/courses/27892/files/6478053/download?wrap=1) 
(https://lynn.instructure.com/courses/27892/files/6478053/download?download_frd=1)

Some camera movements are:

- Pan
- Track
- Truck
- Zolly
- Tilt
- Dolly/Zoom
- Crane

See pages 46 - 51 in the textbook for more details explanations.

Camera Perspective

When we speak of camera perspective we need to consider three types of shots: point of view (POV), objective, or subjective.

POV or Point of View

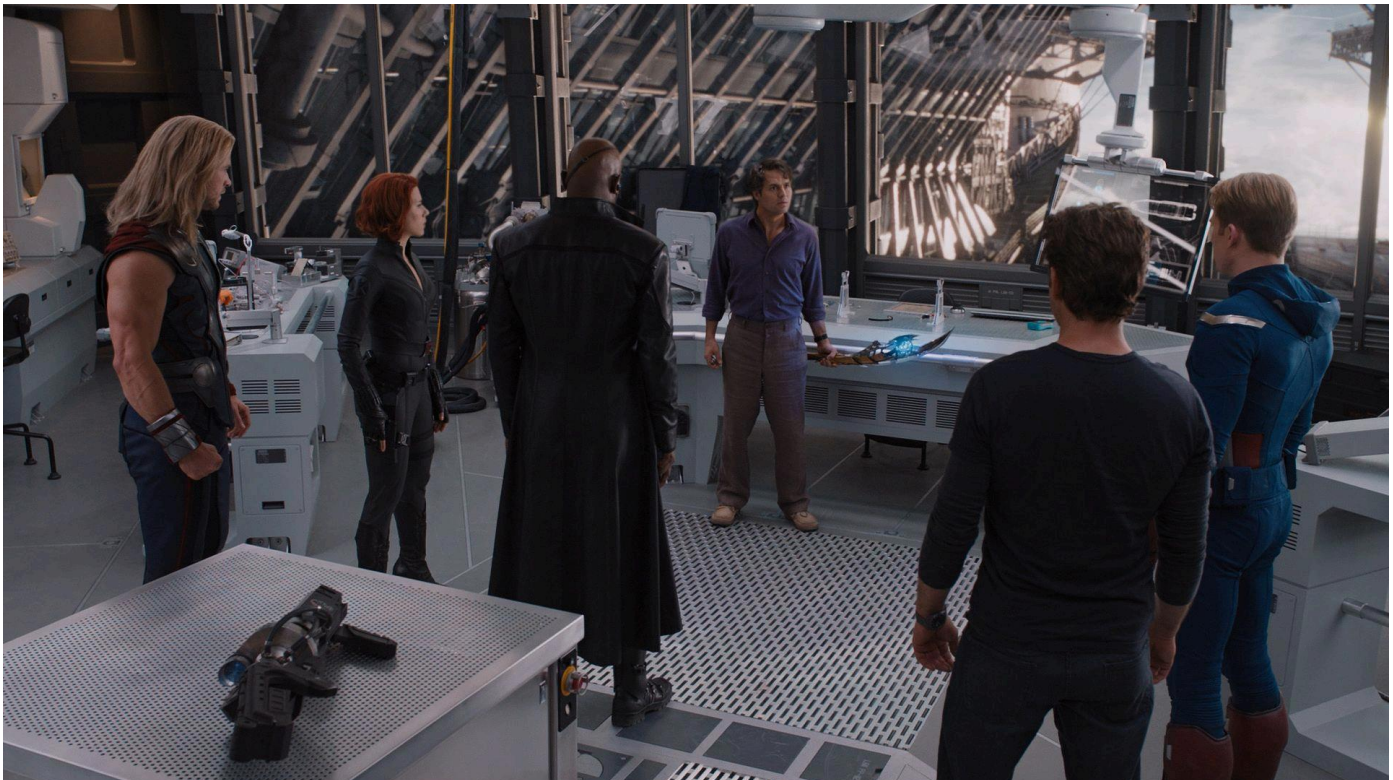
A **POV** shot places the camera near the position of a character whose viewpoint is being depicted. We're not seeing through the characters' eyes but simply standing near them.



OBJECTIVE SHOT

An **objective shot** places the camera in a neutral position as if observing the action taking place from an outsiders perspective; a third-person view. If you've ever driven past an accident scene on the highway and turned to look at what was happening, you were placing yourself objectively into that scene. You are also a rubber-necker slowing down traffic, so don't don't that.

In this scene from Marvel's *The Avengers* we are observing the Avengers in a room having a conversation or argument with one another, ultimately focusing our attention to Dr. Banner holding Loki's staff. We are an observer standing in the room watching as the action unfolds in front of us.



SUBJECTIVE SHOT

A **subjective shot** places the camera in the position of the character, as if looking through the characters' own eyes. It is the most personal and interactive of shots, letting the viewer experience

what the character is experiencing.

In this shot from *Crash*, from Lions Gate Films, the viewer is placed in the position of the thug, as if we are the one holding the gun.



Labeling objective and subjective shots in a storyboard or shot list isn't typically done the same way you would list a POV as most shots tend to be one of these anyway. A close-up shot, for example, can either be objective or subjective depending on the context of the shot. The same can be said for a subjective shot. Therefore you would not label each shot as being either objective or subjective. It is implied in the shot itself. POV's on the other hand, are labeled to indicate their use in order to distinguish them from objective or subjective shots.